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Food Preservation Planning Guide

Turning Harvest Surplus Into Year-Round Food Security

STABILITY • STRUCTURE • GROWTH • COMMUNITY

Prepared by: AgroHouse Foundation™ • Audience: Households & Community Kitchens • Covers: Canning, Freezing, Drying, Fermenting & Storage • Format: Planning Guide

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On behalf of AgroHouse Foundation™ and the families and communities we serve, thank you for your generous donation. Your support directly helps fund community outreach, sustainable agriculture, and workforce development programs.

As a small token of our appreciation, please enjoy this copy of the Food Preservation Planning Guide — our gift to you.

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Why Food Preservation Matters

A productive garden or a good deal on bulk produce is only valuable if the food is put to use before it spoils. Food preservation extends the life of a harvest, smooths out seasonal gaps, and helps households build a dependable pantry. For community-connected growers, preservation also makes it possible to share a surplus harvest safely and effectively over a longer period of time.

This guide introduces the primary preservation methods available to home growers and households: canning, freezing, drying, fermenting, and root cellar-style storage. It also covers safety basics, planning tools, and how to build preservation into your household's overall food security plan.

A Note on Food Safety

Food preservation, especially canning, must follow tested, science-based methods. This guide provides general planning information only. Always follow a current, tested recipe and processing time from a trusted source such as the USDA Complete Guide to Home Canning or your local extension office before preserving any food for storage.

What's Inside

Chapter 1: Choosing the Right Preservation Method

Different foods and different household goals call for different preservation methods. Use the table below as a starting point when deciding how to preserve a given harvest.

Method	Best For	Shelf Life (Properly Stored)
Water bath canning	High-acid foods: fruit, jam, pickles, tomatoes (with added acid)	12–18 months
Pressure canning	Low-acid foods: vegetables, meats, beans, soups	12–18 months
Freezing	Most fruits, vegetables, meats, prepared meals	6–12 months
Drying / dehydrating	Fruit, herbs, vegetables, jerky	6–12 months, cool/dry storage
Fermenting	Cabbage, cucumbers, other vegetables	Several months, refrigerated
Root cellar storage	Potatoes, winter squash, onions, root vegetables	Weeks to several months

Questions to Ask Before You Start

- What equipment do I already have, and what would I need to buy or borrow?
- How much storage space is available for finished, preserved food?
- Does this food need to be acidified, or is it naturally low-acid and require pressure canning?
- How much time can I realistically dedicate to a preservation session?

Chapter 2: Water Bath Canning Basics

Water bath canning is used for high-acid foods, where the acidity itself prevents the growth of harmful bacteria during storage. This includes most fruits, jams, jellies, pickles, and tomatoes when acid is added according to a tested recipe.

Basic Equipment

■ Large water bath canner with a rack

■ Mason jars, new lids, and reusable bands

■ Jar lifter and canning funnel

■ Bubble remover / headspace tool

■ Clean kitchen towels

General Process Overview

- Wash jars and check for cracks or chips; keep lids warm per manufacturer instructions.
- Prepare the recipe exactly as written, using a tested, current source.
- Fill jars, leaving the specified headspace, and remove air bubbles.
- Wipe jar rims clean, apply lids and bands to finger-tight.
- Process in boiling water for the time specified by the recipe, adjusted for your altitude.
- Remove jars, let cool undisturbed for 12–24 hours, then check seals before storing.

Altitude Matters

Processing times increase at higher elevations. Always check an altitude adjustment chart from a trusted canning resource before processing.

Chapter 3: Pressure Canning Basics

Low-acid foods — most vegetables, meats, poultry, and combination foods like soups — require a pressure canner. Pressure canning reaches the higher temperatures needed to destroy bacterial spores that a water bath cannot reach.

Basic Equipment

■ Pressure canner rated for the volume of jars you plan to process (dial-gauge or weighted-gauge)

■ Jars, lids, and bands as with water bath canning

■ A reliable method to check and, if needed, have your dial gauge tested for accuracy

General Process Overview

- Follow a current, tested pressure canning recipe for the specific food.
- Fill jars with the correct headspace and prepare the canner with the manufacturer-specified water level.
- Vent the canner for the required time before pressurizing, to remove trapped air.
- Process at the correct pressure for your altitude and jar size, timing from the point full pressure is reached.
- Allow the canner to depressurize naturally before opening — never force it open early.
- Remove jars, cool undisturbed, and check seals before storing.

Never Skip Pressure Canning for Low-Acid Foods

Water bath canning is not safe for low-acid vegetables, meats, or mixed dishes. Improperly processed low-acid foods can support the growth of Clostridium botulinum, which is undetectable by taste or smell. Always use a pressure canner and a tested recipe for these foods.

Chapter 4: Freezing for Long-Term Storage

Freezing is one of the most accessible preservation methods, requiring less specialized equipment than canning while retaining much of a food's original flavor, texture, and nutrition.

Food Type	Preparation Before Freezing	Approx. Storage Time
Most vegetables	Blanch briefly in boiling water, then cool in ice water before freezing	8–12 months
Fruit	Wash, slice as needed; some fruits benefit from a light sugar or ascorbic acid treatment	8–12 months
Meat	Wrap tightly to prevent freezer burn; label with cut and date	4–12 months, varies by cut
Prepared meals / soups	Cool completely before freezing in portioned containers	2–3 months

- Label every container with contents and date frozen
- Use freezer-safe bags or containers, removing as much air as possible

- Keep a running freezer inventory so nothing is forgotten in the back
- Freeze in meal-sized portions to reduce thawing waste

Chapter 5: Drying & Dehydrating

Drying removes the moisture that supports microbial growth, resulting in lightweight, shelf-stable food that is easy to store. It works well for fruit, vegetables, herbs, and meat (as jerky, with proper curing and temperature control).

Method	Notes
Electric dehydrator	Most consistent results; adjustable temperature and airflow
Oven drying	Works at low temperatures with the door slightly propped for airflow
Air drying (herbs)	Best for low-moisture herbs in a warm, dry, well-ventilated space
Sun drying	Climate-dependent; requires screens and pest protection

■ Cut food into uniform, thin pieces for even drying

■ Dry until brittle (vegetables) or leathery (fruit), depending on food type

■ Cool completely before storing to prevent trapped moisture

■ Store in airtight containers away from light and heat

Chapter 6: Fermenting Basics

Fermentation uses beneficial bacteria to preserve food while adding flavor and, in many cases, additional nutritional benefits. Common home ferments include sauerkraut, kimchi, and pickled vegetables made through fermentation rather than vinegar brining.

General Process Overview

- Prepare vegetables clean and cut as the recipe specifies.
- Submerge fully in a salt brine of the correct concentration, using a tested recipe.
- Use a fermentation weight to keep vegetables under the brine and prevent spoilage.
- Ferment at room temperature, checking daily for the first week.
- Taste periodically until the desired flavor is reached, then refrigerate to slow fermentation.

Signs of a Healthy Ferment vs. a Problem

Healthy: cloudy brine, tangy smell, bubbling. Discard if you see fuzzy mold, an off or putrid smell, or pink/orange discoloration — a thin white film (kahm yeast) can typically be skimmed off, but when in doubt, throw it out.

Chapter 7: Root Cellar & Cool Storage

Some crops store well with little processing at all, given the right temperature and humidity. This method works especially well for root vegetables, winter squash, and alliums.

Food	Ideal Conditions	Approx. Storage Time
Potatoes	Cool, dark, ~45–50°F, moderate humidity	2–4 months

Food	Ideal Conditions	Approx. Storage Time
Winter squash	Cool, dry, ~50–55°F	2–3 months
Onions & garlic	Cool, dry, well-ventilated	3–6 months
Carrots & beets	Cold, humid (packed in damp sand works well)	3–5 months

A cool closet, insulated garage corner, or dedicated root cellar can all work depending on your climate and available space. Check stored produce regularly and remove any items showing spoilage before it spreads.

Chapter 8: Food Safety Fundamentals

Preserving food safely protects your household and anyone you share food with. These fundamentals apply across all preservation methods.

■ Start with clean equipment, work surfaces, and produce

■ Use only tested, current recipes from trusted sources — older or informal recipes may not reflect current safety guidance

■ Never alter processing times, jar sizes, or ingredient ratios in a tested canning recipe

■ Label all preserved food with contents and date

■ When in doubt about a jar's seal, smell, or appearance, discard the contents without tasting

■ Keep a preservation log to track what was made, when, and using which method

Chapter 9: Preservation Planning Worksheet

Use this worksheet to plan a preservation session before your harvest is ready, so you have the right equipment and ingredients on hand.

Food to Preserve	Method	Quantity Expected	Equipment Needed

Chapter 10: Building a Year-Round Preservation Calendar

Spreading preservation tasks across the year prevents overwhelming harvest surges and keeps your pantry consistently stocked. Use the table below to map expected harvests to a preservation plan.

Month	Expected Harvest / Surplus	Planned Preservation Method
Month 1		
Month 2		

Month	Expected Harvest / Surplus	Planned Preservation Method
Month 3		
Month 4		
Month 5		
Month 6		

Resources & Support

- USDA Complete Guide to Home Canning — the standard reference for tested canning recipes and times
- Local UF/IFAS Extension Office — classes, canning equipment testing, and regional guidance
- AgroHouse Foundation™ community partners — for households interested in shared preservation equipment or group canning sessions

This guide is provided for general educational and planning purposes and is not a substitute for a tested recipe or current food safety guidance. Always follow a trusted, current source for specific processing times and methods.